

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-I

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

Q1. Explain glacier mass balance and the apparent paradox of a retreating yet forward-flowing glacier.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (111 words; practice model, not official): Mass balance controls geometry, while the terminus retreats when local loss exceeds ice delivery even though ice motion remains downslope. A glacier is compacted and recrystallised land ice thick enough to deform or slide under gravity; a persistent snowfield need not be a glacier because it may not flow. Accumulation adds snow and refrozen water, ablation removes mass, and net balance is their difference over a stated glacier and period. The equilibrium-line altitude balances annual accumulation and ablation; the climatic snowline is a long-term regional limit, while the snout is the glacier terminus. Ice can continue moving down-valley while the snout retreats when ablation at the terminus exceeds forward ice delivery.

Q2. Explain how wind and episodic water jointly create arid landforms.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (127 words; practice model, not official): Aeolian erosion and deposition interact with weathering, flash runoff, fan building, playa flooding and evaporation. Large thermal ranges, salt crystallisation and episodic wetting weaken exposed rock, while sparse cover leaves debris available to wind and flash runoff. Wind moves coarse particles mainly by surface creep, sand by saltation and fine dust by suspension; deflation removes loose material and abrasion sandblasts exposed surfaces. Deflation hollows, desert pavement, ventifacts, yardangs, zeugens, rock pedestals and inselbergs reflect different combinations of wind, structure and weathering. A barchan has horns pointing downwind under limited sand and one prevailing wind; transverse, longitudinal, parabolic and star dunes indicate different sand, vegetation and wind regimes. Wadis, alluvial fans, bajadas, pediments, playas and salt flats show that episodic runoff and evaporation are integral to desert geomorphology.

Q3. Distinguish mineral-resource geography from energy geography with suitable Indian examples.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (111 words; practice model, not official): Mineral geography asks where ores and industrial minerals occur, while energy geography asks where usable power can be produced, so India's shield-based ore belts and its solar and wind corridors do not overlap. Economic geography classifies minerals as ferrous metallic, non-ferrous metallic, non-metallic industrial and mineral fuels, so coal and petroleum are mineral resources and not merely fuels. Energy resources are classified twice over: conventional commercial against non-conventional newer sources, and exhaustible stock against renewable flow. Solar capacity concentrates in the dry high-insolation belts of Rajasthan and Gujarat while wind concentrates along Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Karnataka and Maharashtra coasts and passes, so the renewable map does not mirror the coal map.

Q4. Explain how caste is assuming new identities and associational forms in contemporary India.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (112 words; practice model, not official): Caste is changing register rather than disappearing: ritual allocation and public purity enforcement have weakened while association, network capital and political mobilisation have expanded, and endogamy has changed least. Endogamy, hierarchy, hereditary membership and traditional occupational linkage are the four classically cited defining features of caste, and they weaken at very different rates. Urbanisation, schooling and non-farm employment have broken most hereditary occupational allocation, making the caste-occupation link the weakest joint of the system, although stigmatised occupations and their inheritance have not disappeared. Jati-level associations and caste panchayats arbitrate disputes, enforce endogamy norms and organise political mobilisation, which is how caste re-enters public life as organisation and network rather than as ritual.

Q5. Contrast the isolationist, assimilationist and integrationist positions in Indian tribal policy.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (111 words; practice model, not official): Elwin diagnosed exploitative contact and prescribed protection, Ghurye diagnosed cultural lag and prescribed absorption, and Nehru rejected both extremes in favour of development on tribal terms, while what actually occurred was uneven acculturation. Verrier Elwin argued from fieldwork among central Indian tribal groups that unregulated contact with markets, moneylenders and settlers exploited tribal communities and eroded their culture, so protective limitation of outside contact was necessary. G.S. Ghurye's historically influential and contested argument described tribes as

backward Hindus at a lower stage of acculturation and favoured faster absorption into mainstream Hindu social and economic life; the phrase must be quoted as his argument, not as a description of Adivasi identity.

Q6. How did pre-Congress political associations prepare the ground for the Indian National Congress?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (130 words; practice model, not official): Provincial associations created leaders, publicity networks and a constitutional repertoire that the Congress scaled into an all-India platform. The British Indian Association was formed in Bengal in 1851 and represented an early elite form of organised political articulation. Dadabhai Naoroji founded the East India Association in London in 1866 to place Indian questions before British public opinion. The Poona Sarvajanik Sabha emerged in 1870 as an important western-India forum claiming to represent public interests. Surendranath Banerjea and Ananda Mohan Bose founded the Indian Association in 1876 and pursued broader political mobilisation. The Madras Mahajan Sabha became a major pre-Congress political association in the Madras Presidency and helped develop regional public work before the all-India platform. The first Indian National Congress session met at Bombay in December 1885 with seventy-two delegates.

Q7. Why was Champaran a methodological turning point in India's national movement?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (95 words; practice model, not official): Champaran joined local peasant initiative, public inquiry, principled law-breaking and negotiated redress, giving Gandhi Indian credibility without yet becoming an all-India anti-state campaign. Raj Kumar Shukla persistently brought Gandhi to Champaran in 1917, showing that local agency preceded national intervention. Champaran cultivators challenged tinkathia, which required indigo cultivation on 3/20 of a tenant's holding, and planter demands associated with release from that system. Gandhi's team recorded about 8,000 cultivator statements; an official inquiry led to a 25% refund of illegal dues, while later abolition of tinkathia must be kept distinct from that refund.

Q8. Explain why the founding leadership deferred linguistic reorganisation between 1947 and 1948 although the Congress had accepted the linguistic principle since 1921.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (93 words; practice model, not official): The deferral was a judgement about sequencing under post-Partition stress rather than a repudiation of a principle the Congress had already applied to its own organisation in 1921. With the involvement of the masses in the national movement after 1919 the Congress undertook political mobilisation in the mother tongue and in 1921 amended its own constitution to reorganise its regional branches on a linguistic basis, and it committed itself repeatedly thereafter to redrawing provincial boundaries on linguistic lines, so that the principle was long settled and only its timing became contested after Partition.

Q9. Why should temple vocabulary be read as a grammar of movement and hierarchy rather than as a decorative glossary?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (121 words; practice model, not official): Temple vocabulary describes ritual approach. The devotee does not enter a temple into a flat space but moves from the outer platform and porch into progressively restricted zones. Terms such as jagati, ardhmandapa, mandapa, antarala and garbhagriha therefore map sacred hierarchy. At Khajuraho, UNESCO's plan sequence itself proves that spatial order is doctrinally meaningful. In South India too, the distinction between vimana, gopura, prakara and mandapa explains how temple growth changed devotional experience over time. This matters in UPSC because analysis should explain how architecture works, not merely what it is called. Once vocabulary is linked to access, procession, congregation and sanctity, the temple becomes legible as an institution of worship and power. Without that spatial grammar, style labels remain superficial.

Q10. Why did the fiscal crisis become a social revolution in France?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (105 words; practice model, not official): Fiscal breakdown opened the political arena, but legal privilege, subsistence stress, Enlightenment legitimacy and multi-class mobilisation determined the Revolution's depth. The financially troubled monarchy summoned the Estates-General in May 1789, opening the old regime to a constitutional challenge. Clergy and nobility held legal and fiscal privileges, while the Third Estate formed about ninety-five per cent of the population in old NCERT and bore exclusion and taxation. Monarchical bankruptcy, tax inequality, bad harvests and bread stress supplied the immediate crisis that Enlightenment ideas translated into a legitimacy struggle. Bourgeois leadership drove institutional rupture, peasants attacked feudal burdens, and workers, artisans and the Paris crowd pushed radicalisation.

Q11. Account for the world distribution of hot and mid-latitude deserts.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (161 words; practice model, not official): Subtropical subsidence, offshore flow, cold currents, continentality and rain shadow combine differently across named deserts. Descending air in subtropical high-pressure belts warms adiabatically, lowers relative humidity and suppresses cloud development, helping locate many hot deserts around the subtropical margins. On western subtropical margins and some interiors, prevailing airflow may be offshore or have travelled over dry land, limiting oceanic moisture supply; it is one cause among several. Cold currents such as the Humboldt Current or Peru Current and the Benguela Current stabilise lower air and reduce convection, so coastal deserts may be cool or foggy yet receive little rain; cold water does not automatically produce rainfall. Mid-latitude interiors lie far from maritime moisture sources and may be enclosed by large land masses, creating severe annual thermal ranges and low precipitation. Mountains remove moisture on windward slopes and leave leeward basins dry; Patagonia east of the Andes is a classic example, while rain shadow often reinforces rather than solely creates a desert.

Q12. Analyse the dual role of the summer maritime mechanism in making eastern-margin regions both agriculturally rich and hazard-prone.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (151 words; practice model, not official): The same summer inflow of warm moist maritime air that gives a long wet growing season supporting rice, tea and dense populations also brings typhoons, floods and surges onto the same low-lying coastal plains. The mechanism that makes a region agriculturally rich is the same one that makes it hazardous: the summer inflow of warm moist maritime air gives a long wet growing season supporting dense rural populations while also bringing tropical cyclones onto the same low-lying coastal plains. Typhoons are intense tropical cyclones that originate in the Pacific Ocean and move westwards to the coasts bordering the South China Sea, most frequent in late summer July to September, and can be very disastrous. Warm wet summers support luxuriant forests, with regional examples including eucalyptus forests in NSW, sugar-cane thriving in Natal, the maize belt of the Gulf-type region, and rice and tea as characteristic crops of the monsoonal China-type lands.

Q13. Examine the significance of straits, canals and isthmuses in international trade.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (160 words; practice model, not official): Narrow passages compress world movement into small spaces, so they shorten routes, concentrate traffic and convert commercial geography into strategic geography by making disruption at a single point a global cost event. Transport is the circulatory system of an economy because it moves raw materials, labour, finished goods, information and strategic power across space, and trade geography grows out of connectivity, cost, time and chokepoints. Containerisation standardised the cargo unit, collapsed handling time and cost, made intermodal transfer routine, permitted fragmentation of production across countries, and concentrated traffic at fewer deep-draught, high-crane-productivity, well-connected hubs with feeder services. Canals and straits matter because they shorten or control routes, so a disruption at one narrow passage lengthens voyages and raises freight and insurance costs far beyond the affected region. India's trade is coast-oriented but hinterland-dependent, with the western seaboard acting as the gateway for container and petroleum flows and the eastern coast tied to bulk minerals, coal, fertilizers and East Asian links.

Q14. Cultural diversity in India marks disadvantage but does not produce it. Critically examine.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (207 words; practice model, not official): Diversity correlates with deprivation only where identity axes reinforce historical exclusion and geographic remoteness; where they cross-cut, diversity coexists with prosperity, so exclusion rather than difference is the mechanism. Where identity axes do not align, disadvantage on one axis is often offset on another, so no single identity always predicts deprivation and group conflict is less intense. Where remoteness, low literacy, asset-poverty and minority status stack on the same household, ordinary diversity compounds into marginality and the correlation the examiner asks about becomes strong. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs state-wise list dated 9 July 2024 identifies 75 Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups in 18 States and the Union Territory of Andaman and Nicobar Islands, with legacy criteria including pre-agricultural technology, low literacy, stagnant or declining population and subsistence economy. Prosperous linguistic-minority trading communities in metropolitan India and several Sikh and Jain business communities show that cultural distinctiveness does not by itself predict deprivation. A landless labouring household of the locally dominant caste in a poor region shows class-based deprivation operating without a distinct cultural marker, so the correlation is not symmetric. Historical exclusion, geographic remoteness and asset-poverty are the causal drivers of deprivation, and cultural diversity is usually the visible marker rather than the mechanism that produces it.

Q15. Examine the claim that Indian kinship is uniform, using matrilineal evidence.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (137 words; practice model, not official): Patriliney is dominant but not universal, and matrilineal descent among the Khasi and traditionally the Nair shows regional variation in property and lineage without implying matriarchal authority. Patrilineal systems trace descent, surname and property transmission through the father's line and constitute India's dominant kinship pattern. Matrilineal descent among the Khasi of Meghalaya and, traditionally, the Nair of Kerala vests descent, surname and property in the female line, and the youngest Khasi daughter customarily inherits the ancestral home. Matrilineal descent concerns descent and property and must not be equated with matriarchal authority, because ritual and public authority can still rest with maternal uncles rather than with women themselves. The family remains the primary institution transmitting caste, religious and gender norms across

generations, which makes it the site where broader social change or resistance to it first becomes visible.

Q16. Compare British policy toward Afghanistan and Burma.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (140 words; practice model, not official): Afghanistan was preserved as a controlled buffer against a great-power threat, while Burma was annexed where commercial and strategic expansion faced no equivalent rival. The Great Game describes Anglo-Russian rivalry in Central Asia that shaped British policy toward Afghanistan. The First Anglo-Afghan War of 1839-42 ended in a disastrous British retreat from Kabul. The Second Anglo-Afghan War of 1878-80 reflected Lytton's forward policy. The Treaty of Gandamak of 1879 followed the Second Anglo-Afghan War and expanded British influence over Afghan external affairs. The First Anglo-Burmese War of 1824-26 ended with the Treaty of Yandabo. The Second Anglo-Burmese War of 1852 led to the annexation of Lower Burma under Dalhousie. The Third Anglo-Burmese War of 1885 led to the annexation of Upper Burma under Dufferin. Afghanistan and Nepal were managed mainly as buffers, whereas Burma was conquered and annexed in stages.

Q17. Was Gandhi's withdrawal after Chauri Chaura a strategic necessity or a lost opportunity? Examine.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (187 words; practice model, not official): Judged by Gandhi's own premises the withdrawal was obligatory once mass violence broke non-violent discipline; judged by momentum it was costly, though Bardoli's planned escalation remained untested rather than defeated. R. Palme Dutt's class-protection thesis reads the withdrawal as shielding propertied interests from a radicalising peasantry, but Bipin Chandra's rebuttal shows the Chauri Chaura crowd had no anti-property intent and that agrarian unrest was already ebbing, making a discipline-based reading more defensible. Gandhi announced that mass civil disobedience and tax refusal would begin selectively in Bardoli taluqa of Surat district, with the rest of the country maintaining discipline so attention could concentrate there. On 4 February 1922 a Congress-Khilafat procession at Chauri Chaura in Gorakhpur district clashed with police, then attacked and burned the police station, killing twenty-two policemen. Gandhi persuaded the Congress Working Committee to ratify withdrawal of Non-Cooperation on 12 February 1922 in the resolution known as the Bardoli resolution, named for the place where escalation had been planned. Gandhi was arrested in March 1922 and sentenced to six years' imprisonment, and the Caliphate was abolished by Mustafa Kemal in 1924, ending the Khilafat issue.

Q18. Compare Junagadh, Hyderabad and Kashmir as three distinct failures of the accession formula rather than three versions of one problem.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (192 words; practice model, not official): The three cases failed the formula in three different ways - a ruler at odds with his people, a ruler seeking sovereignty, and a ruler paralysed between two dominions - which is precisely why three different instruments were used to settle them. Junagadh was a small Saurashtra state surrounded by Indian territory and without geographical contiguity with Pakistan, yet its Nawab announced accession to Pakistan, its overwhelmingly Hindu population organised a movement that forced him to flee, and its Dewan Shah Nawaz Bhutto then invited the Government of India to intervene. Tribal invaders entered Kashmir in October 1947 and pushed towards Srinagar, Maharaja Hari Singh appealed to India for military assistance, and troops were flown in only after the Instrument of Accession had been signed, so invasion preceded accession and accession preceded the airlift. The Government of India signed a standstill agreement with the Nizam of Hyderabad in November 1947 in the hope that negotiation and representative government inside the state would make merger easier, so force in Hyderabad came after, and not instead of, a documented attempt at settlement. A plebiscite held in Junagadh in February 1948 went in favour of joining India.

Q19. Regional adaptation, not imperial imitation, best explains provincial Indo-Islamic architecture. Discuss.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (185 words; practice model, not official): Provincial Indo-Islamic architecture is best explained through adaptation because the same broad arch-dome vocabulary is re-solved differently under different climates, materials and courts. Bengal is the clearest starting point. Its mosques rely heavily on brick and black basalt, while the sloping Bangla roof translates a hut-derived, rain-responsive form into masonry. This is not imitation of Delhi but regional construction logic. Jaunpur makes the political dimension equally visible. The Sharqi style emphasises the prayer-hall facade and famously avoids minars. Atala Mosque shows how a regional sultanate could mark identity through the screen front itself. Malwa or Mandu adds a climatic answer: large windows, airy pavilions, baulis and locally available materials create an architecture of ventilation and water control. Bijapur in the Deccan pushes another line, turning the bulbous dome and three-arched facade into signs of engineering ambition, with Gol Gumbaz as the signature monument. The comparison proves that provincial schools are not inferior branches of a Delhi tree. They are evidence that Indo-Islamic architecture became Indian by becoming regional. A mature answer should conclude that local climate, material and patronage give the category its real diversity.

Q20. Was the Concert of Europe an instrument of peace or repression?

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (136 words; practice model, not official): It was both: consultation moderated conflict among powers while Carlsbad and intervention congresses suppressed liberal and national movements within states. The Concert was a diplomatic habit of great-power consultation and periodic congresses, not a permanent treaty-state or the same institution as the Holy Alliance. The Carlsbad Decrees of 1819 imposed censorship, university control and investigation against liberal and nationalist activity in the German states. The Troppau and Laibach congresses asserted intervention against revolutions, linking great-power order to domestic repression. The Congress of Verona in 1822 approved French intervention in Spain and was the last major effective congress of the old system. The Concert accepted Belgian independence in 1830, demonstrating selective adaptation rather than rigid restoration. Vienna achieved substantial great-power peace and diplomatic consultation while denying consent and repressing liberal-national change, creating stability with a legitimacy deficit.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS